

Your Echocardiogram

Why this test?

An echo uses ultrasound to assess heart muscle, chambers and valves. It can help evaluate a murmur, breathlessness or known heart disease.

What to expect

A standard transthoracic echo uses a probe and gel on the chest. It does not use ionizing radiation. Follow separate instructions if you are having a TEE or stress echo.

Words in the report

EF is the percentage of blood ejected by the left ventricle with each beat. About 55-70% is a commonly used normal range. Regurgitation means valve leakage; stenosis means narrowing. Mild findings need context, not an automatic procedure.

What happens next?

Review important findings and any follow-up interval with the ordering clinician. Preserved EF does not exclude heart failure, and a resting echo does not rule out every coronary problem.

Questions to bring

- What are the important findings in my echo?
- Does any valve finding need follow-up?
- Does this result explain my symptoms, and what happens next?

My next step / follow-up: _____

Urgent symptoms: Call 911 for severe chest symptoms, fainting, stroke symptoms or severe trouble breathing. Do not wait for a scheduled test or its report.

Full guide and references: <https://bmorecardiology.com/tests/echocardiogram.html>

Source: AHA: Echocardiogram (2025)

Source: AHA: Ejection Fraction and Heart Failure (2025)

Independent educational resource. Use your own clinician's instructions.